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Inligtingtegnologie / Lefapha la Boetšenere,
Tikologo ya Kago le Theknološi ya Tshedimošo

Self-Study 1b: Conflict & Team Dynamics

BSS 310 Engineering Management 2026

Lecturer: Prof. Michael Ayomoh



Team Dynamics

Expected Learning Outcomes for the Current Lecture (A Continuation of “Conflict & Team Dynamics”)

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- **Define** Team Dynamics and gain a deep **understanding** of peripherals with respect to Team Dynamics
- Discuss types of teams and strategies for improving Team Dynamics
- Discuss the causes of poor Team Dynamics and apply the entire concept to the semester group work

Outline of Presentation

- Introduction
- Definition of Team Dynamics
- Some Facts about Team Dynamics
- Type of Teams
- Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics
- Causes of Poor Team Dynamics

Together we are able



Short Videos on Group Work & Team Dynamics showing volatility

[project management funny video #entertainment #project #entertainment management](#)

[Team Leader Funny |Corporate memes | Funny Team Work Video](#)

Definition of Team Dynamics

- A team can be defined as two or more people working together to interdependently meet a specific goal or purpose. A team can be for the long term or come together for a few hours.
- Team dynamics is the unconscious, psychological forces that influence the direction of a team's behaviour and performance. It can be likened to a sea undercurrent which can float a sailing boat in a different direction to the intended direction.

<https://www.teamtechnology.co.uk/team/dynamics/definition/>

Definition of Team Dynamics

- **Team Dynamics** is defined as the motivating forces that propel a team towards its goals or mission. Team dynamics is orchestrated by the interplay amongst **team members**, the **task** at hand and the **team as a whole**.

[Source:https://mikecardus.com/10-team-dynamics-that-all-great-teams-share/](https://mikecardus.com/10-team-dynamics-that-all-great-teams-share/)

Some Facts about Team Dynamics

- Team dynamics can be good - for example, when they improve the overall performance of a team and/or get the best out of individual team members. They can also be bad - for example, when they cause unproductive conflict, demotivation, and prevent the team from achieving its goals.
- Team dynamics is often orchestrated by the **nature of the team's work, the personalities within the team, their working relationships with other people, and the environment in which the team works.**

Some Facts about Team Dynamics

Team dynamics is critical for an organisation's success. Without positive team dynamics, businesses can't fully leverage the potential of your employees and tap into their skills and experience.

No two teams are exactly the same, so improving team dynamics starts with identifying any issues and formulating a tailored strategy for your team.

<https://www.deakinco.com/media-centre/news/6-strategies-for-managing-and-improving-team-dynamics>

Some Facts about Team Dynamics

- A team with a positive dynamics tend to have team members who trust each other. They can work towards collective decisions and they are held accountable for outcomes. A team with good group dynamics may be constructive and productive, and it may demonstrate mutual understanding and self-corrective behaviour. On the other hand, poor group dynamics can be disruptive for successful decision making and work outcomes.
- Team dynamics matters because they impact things like creativity, productivity and effectiveness. Since group work is integral to organisations, for business leaders, addressing team dynamics can lead to better work outcomes, customer satisfaction and an improved bottom line.

Some Facts about Team Dynamics

- A group with a positive dynamics is easy to spot. Team members trust one another, they work towards a collective decision, and they hold one another accountable for making things happen.
- In a group with poor team dynamics, people's behaviour disrupts work. As a result, the group may not come to any decision, or it may make the wrong choice, because group members could not explore options effectively.

Types of Teams

- Real Team
- Virtual Team
- Mixed Team

Real Team

Usually, a real team is one in which members can physically make contact



Real Team

- Face to face encounter hence full expression of emotions.
- Absolute ability to express complete sense.
- Disagreements among members can be easily managed if all parties are willing and interested to achieve this.

Virtual Team

Mostly a team that cannot make physical contact



Virtual Team

- Meeting virtually is a necessity in today's happenings of global pandemics such as Covid-19 amongst others and global dynamic & integrated economy.
- Organizations can gather experts together regardless of geographic location.
- Companies can give employees greater flexibility where they work, and
- Virtual technology can reduce the negative effects of hierarchy, allowing more equal participation among colleagues.

<https://globalworkplaceanalyticcs.com>

Virtual Team

When things go wrong with virtual teams, it can get ugly fast.

When people lack information, when they are uncertain about why someone disagreed with them, they are much more likely to take it personally.

- Little or No means to express emotions.

Occasional inability to express complete sense.

Disagreements among virtual teams can escalate much more quickly than in face-to-face encounters.

<https://www.gsb.stanford.edu/insights/lindred-greer-why-virtual-teams-have-more-conflict>

Mixed Team

- A combined attribute of both real and virtual teams
- Can have a much complex dynamics compared to a strictly real or virtual team

Mixed Team



Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

There's a lot of research regarding what works in **team building** and **team dynamics**. The challenge is using what works for the team at that time. The list of points below highlights some things that productive teams share.

Source: <https://mikecardus.com/10-team-dynamics-that-all-great-teams-share/>

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Knowing the team

- Conduct of diagnosis on what is going wrong in the team by doing a **team health check**.
- Observe the team at work and conduct individual interviews in a private, safe and confidential space.
- Talk to other relevant people, such as customers and line managers, to find out as much as you can about your team's problems.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Selection of a Team Leader

- A common mistake is the failure to recognise that any team endeavour requires the identification of a leader. This person isn't there to tell people what to do per se, but to guide the process, ensure a steady supply of resources, coordinate efforts, and assist in cross-functional-teamwork.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Definition of Roles and Responsibilities

- Teams that lack focus or direction can quickly develop poor dynamics, as people struggle to understand their role in the group. Hence, a **team charter**—defining the group's mission and objectives, and everyone's responsibilities as soon as the team is formed should be created. Everyone should have a copy of the document, and be reminded of it regularly.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Creation of Goals and Objectives

- In any team, recognizing and understanding the goals is paramount. Often, organizations have short or long-term goals or both actively operational. Project teams must understand and set **technical and process goals**.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Enhancement of Team Culture

- Team-building exercises should be used to encourage stronger relationship amongst team members. Creation of a workplace that supports employee well-being, success and enthusiasm for work. Diversity must be valued and thoughts about how trust and respect can be built amongst team members should be given a high priority. Support provided should include sharing of ideas through an inclusive work culture.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Effective Communication

- Open communication is central to good team dynamics, so make sure that everyone is communicating clearly. Include all of the forms of communication that your group uses – emails, meetings and shared documents to avoid any ambiguity.
- If the status of a project changes, or if there is an announcement to make, team members should be informed as soon as possible. By so doing, it can be ensured that everyone has the same information.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Effective Communication.....Contd.

- Opinionated team members can overwhelm their quieter colleagues in meetings. Where this happens, techniques such as [Crawford's Slip Writing Method](#), can be used.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Breaking Down Barriers

- Use **team-building exercises** to help everyone get to know one another, particularly when new members join the group. These exercises ease new colleagues into the group gently, and also help to combat the "black sheep effect," which happens when group members turn against people they consider to be odd or different from them.
- The [Johari Window](#) is one good technique that can assist people open up. Also, occasionally there could be a need to lead by example by sharing what is hoped the group will achieve, along with "safe" personal information about oneself, such as valuable lessons learned etc.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Paying Attention

- It is important to always pay attention to team members and know what is going on. Look out for unacceptable behaviours, challenges faced by individuals or groups. Reinforce positive behaviours like successful collaboration, sharing of ideas, trust and respect.
- It must also be noted that teams with excellent dynamics still require ongoing observation, correction, guidance and training needed. Hence, as a team leader or an aspiring leader, be prepared to continue providing your team with the necessary virtue.

Strategies for Improving Team Dynamics

Summary:

- Knowing the Team
- Selection of a Team Leader
- Definition of Roles and Responsibilities
- Creation of Goals and Objectives
- Enhancement of Team Culture
- Effective Communication
- Breaking Down Barriers
- Paying Attention.

Causes of Poor Team Dynamics

<https://davidsummertonconsulting.co.uk/2015/03/10/what-causes-poor-group-dynamics/>

Causes of Poor Group Dynamics

What Causes Poor Group Dynamics?

Group leaders and team members can contribute to a negative group dynamics. Let's look at some of the common problems in here:

- **Weak leadership:** when a team lacks a strong leader, a more dominant member of the group can often take charge. This can lead to a lack of direction, infighting or a focus on the wrong priorities.
- **Evaluation apprehension:** Team members' perceptions can also create a negative dynamics in the team. Evaluation apprehension happens when people feel that they are being judged excessively harshly by other group members, and they hold back their opinions as a result.

Causes of Poor Group Dynamics

Little or No Attention

- Watch out for the warning signs of poor group dynamics.
- Pay particular attention to frequent unanimous decisions, as these can be a sign of [groupthink](#) , [bullying](#) , or free riding. If there are frequent unanimous decisions in a team, consider exploring new ways to encourage people to discuss their views, or to share them anonymously.

Causes of Poor Group Dynamics

- **Blocking:** this happens when team members behave in a way that disrupts the flow of information in the group. People can adopt blocking roles such as:
 - **The aggressor:** this person often disagrees with others, or is inappropriately outspoken.
 - **The negator:** this group member is often critical of others' ideas.
 - **The withdrawer:** this person doesn't participate in the discussion.
 - **The recognition seeker:** this group member is boastful, or dominates the session.
 - **The joker:** this person introduces humor at inappropriate times.

Causes of Poor Group Dynamics

- **Authority and Groupthink:** Excessive deference to authority can have a stagnating effect of teams as people would rather agree with the leader than offering innovative ideas and opinions hence, holding back from expressing their own opinions. This prevents people from fully exploring alternative solutions.
- **Free riding:** Here, some group members take it easy, and leave their colleagues to do all the work. Free riders may work hard on their own, but limit their contributions in group situations; this is known as "**social loafing**."

Looking Back at the Lecture Outcomes

Has this lecture shaped or reshaped your mindset about the dynamics of teamwork?

Do you think this lecture has positioned you to be a project team leader?

What is your greatest takeaway from this lecture with respect to team dynamics?

Lecture Resources

Recommended reading:

Project Management - A Multi-disciplinary Approach (4th edition)
Chapter 7: Conflicts

<https://davidsummertonconsulting.co.uk/2015/03/10/what-causes-poor-group-dynamics/>

<https://globalworkplaceanalyticcs.com>

The End

Next Topic

- Unit 1: Needs Analysis



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